

Cristian Navarro

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Primary: Political Economy, Economic History
Secondary: Development Economics

EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Economics Centro de Estudios Monetarios y Financieros (CEMFI)	2022 – 2026 (expected)
Visiting scholar Uppsala University - Sponsor: Luca Repetto	Spring 2025
MSc in Economics and Finance Centro de Estudios Monetarios y Financieros (CEMFI)	2020 – 2022
MSc in Economics Universitat de Barcelona	2018 – 2020
B.A. in Economics Universitat de Barcelona	2012 – 2016

REFERENCES

Carlos Sanz Bank of Spain carlossanz@bde.es	Samuel Bentolila CEMFI bentolila@cemfi.es	Tom Zohar CEMFI tom.zohar@cemfi.es	Luca Repetto Uppsala University luca.repetto@nek.uu.se
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JOB MARKET PAPER

“Autocrats Remake the State: Evidence from Francoist Spain” (joint with Ricard Grebol)
In autocracies, personnel decisions often prioritize ideological alignment over merit. We investigate how such ideology-driven personnel selection affects the quality of the public workforce and its implications for state capacity. We examine this in the context of a large-scale political purge and reorganization of primary school teachers carried out by the Francoist dictatorship following the Spanish Civil War (1936 - 1939). We construct a novel dataset linking newly digitized purge archives and administrative records that track teacher careers, and document that more competent teachers were disproportionately dismissed and that average experience declined by about 2.2 years (12.5%). Local shortages created by the purge were partly offset by regime efforts to reassign teachers across municipalities, yet coordination frictions generated widespread and persistent staffing deficits that spread to areas not directly affected. Our findings show how ideology-driven personnel reforms can erode public workforce expertise and weaken the state’s capacity to deliver essential services, providing a mechanism through which autocratic consolidation entails lasting capacity costs.

WORKING PAPERS

“Seeds of Prejudice: The impact of British colonization on attitudes towards sexual minorities” (joint with Alexsandros Cavgias) - Submitted
This paper provides the first causal test of the widely debated hypothesis that British colonial institutions promoted sexual prejudice—defined as negative attitudes toward sexual minorities—in postcolonial societies. We document five main findings. First, after accounting for differences in contemporary economic development, OLS estimates from a cross-country sample of former European colonies reveal that former British colonies exhibit higher sexual prejudice than those of other European powers. Second, Geo-RDD estimates show that former British colonies have significantly greater sexual prejudice than former Portuguese colonies in Southern and Eastern Africa, where local norms did not systematically condemn same-sex relations. Third, Geo-RDD estimates indicate that former British and French colonies display similar levels of sexual prejudice in Western Africa, where a higher share of the population adheres to religious norms condemning same-sex acts. Fourth, additional evidence from areas in South America and Southeast Asia not characterized by homophobic social norms before colonization reinforces the external validity of our findings from Southeastern Africa. Finally, mechanisms analysis suggests that the persistence of sodomy laws fully accounts for the negative association between British colonial origin and contemporary sexual prejudice across countries. Overall, our results indicate that British colonial origin notably increased sexual prejudice in societies with social norms different from the penal codes imposed by colonizers.

“Personalized Employment Support for the Homeless: Evidence from a Randomized Evaluation” (joint with Miguel Almunia and Begoña Varela Merino) - Submitted

We evaluate the impact of a randomized intervention designed to promote labor market integration among people experiencing homelessness in Spain. Participants were randomly assigned to either a personalized employment program, featuring intensive caseworker support and financial assistance, or to the traditional employment model. Short-term results show substantial gains for the treatment group in housing stability, employment, income, and life satisfaction. However, these differences largely dissipated after six months, as the outcomes of those in the traditional model improved. The findings highlight both the potential of personalized approaches to accelerate integration and the challenges of sustaining long-term effects in homelessness interventions.

WORK IN PROGRESS

“Ballot measures, political advertising, and contribution caps” (joint with Pello Aspuru)

“When should I expect the Spanish Inquisition? The Economics of Denunciations” (joint with Álvaro Sánchez-Leache)

CONFERENCE AND SEMINAR PRESENTATIONS

III Workshop in Economic History (Uppsala), III Spanish Workshop in Development Economics, Madrid Empirical Social Sciences Conference 2025

SITES-GLO Annual Conference, II Spanish Workshop in Development Economics, Simposio Asociación Española de Economía 2024

PRE-PhD PUBLICATIONS

“Globalisation and natural resource abundance. Is export diversification possible? A comparison of export composition in Chile and Norway, 1870-2017”, with Marc Badia-Miró, José Peres-Cajías and Anna Carreras Marin. *Natural Resources and Divergence: A Comparison of Andean and Nordic Trajectories*, 2021. Palgrave Macmillan. DOI: [10.1007/978-3-030-71044-6_2](https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-71044-6_2)

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

CEMFI, Research Assistant for Professor Monica Martinez-Bravo (part-time) 2021 – 2023

Universitat de Barcelona, Research Assistant for Professor Marc Badia-Miró (part-time) 2018 – 2019

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Uncertainty and Information (Microeconomics II) Winter 2024, Winter 2025
CEMFI - TA for Professor Guillermo Caruana

Markets and Organizations Spring 2023
CEMFI – TA for Professor Guillermo Caruana and Wouter Vergote

PREVIOUS WORKING EXPERIENCE

Sant Cugat del Vallès City Council – Project officer Apr 2018 – Sep 2018

PricewaterhouseCoopers – Business Consultant Aug 2016 – Apr 2018

GRANTS, FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

CEMFI doctoral fellowship, María de Maeztu Unit of Excellence 2022 – 2026

María de Maeztu Scholarship 2020 – 2022

Extraordinary award for the MSc (Universitat de Barcelona) 2020

Fundació Catalunya La Pedrera Scholarship 2018 – 2020

Extraordinary award for the B.A. (Universitat de Barcelona) 2016

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Last update: October 24, 2025

OTHER INFORMATION

Languages: English (fluent), Catalan and Spanish (native)

Programming: Stata, R, QGIS, Python, LaTeX

Citizenship: Spanish